> considered him a puppet (‘a moolee’, or radish, was the word he used) & that he had no honour in his own country . . .[82]

It was around this time that the more perceptive of the British in Afghanistan began to realise the very delicate nature of their position and the fragility of the regime they had installed. Abraham Roberts began to worry about the extended lines of communication, the much reduced size of the British garrison, and the way that small pockets of troops were left in key urban areas where they were vulnerable to insurrection. He was soon writing to Auckland to express his anxieties about the ‘numerous Corps being spread over the Country, free from all Military control, and managed by the Political Department and with so little judgement and without any Military experience’.[83] Meanwhile, General Nott in Kandahar blamed Macnaghten and his political advisers. ‘They drink their claret, draw large salaries, go about with a rabble at their heels,’ he complained to his daughters.

> All are well paid by John Bull, or rather by the oppressed cultivators of the land in Hindustan. The Calcutta treasury is drained of its rupees, and *good natured* Lord Auckland approves and confirms all. In the meantime all goes wrong here. We are hated by the people . . . Thus it is to employ men selected by patronage. The conduct of one thousand and one Politicals has ruined our cause, and bared the throat of every European in this country to the sword and knife of the revengeful Affghan, and unless several regiments be quickly sent, not a man will be left to note the fall of his comrades. Nothing but force will ever make them submit to the hated Shah.[84]

Even the usually optimistic Burnes began to be anxious. ‘There is no two days fixity of purpose,’ he complained privately to his friend Jacob, ‘no plan of the future policy, external or internal, on which you can depend a week. The bit-by-bit system prevails. Nothing comprehensive is looked to . . . and I, for one, begin to think that Wade [who had retired back in Ludhiana] will be the luckiest of all of us, as he will be away from the breakdown; for unless a new leaf is turned, break down we shall.’[85]

The first signs of concerted armed resistance took place in May 1840 when a column marching from Kandahar towards Ghazni was attacked by 2,000 Ghilzai horsemen. The Ghilzai were quickly driven off, leaving 200 dead behind them, but they learned the lesson that a frontal attack in flat open country was not the way to tackle the British. Then, in mid-August, less than a year after Shah Shuja had entered Kabul in triumph, news arrived in the capital of exactly what the British had most dreaded. Dost